

Theorizing Educational Transfer: toward a conceptual map of the context of cross-national attraction

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ABSTRACT This article highlights some of the current methodological issues surrounding how to analyze and understand educational transfer with particular reference to cross-national attraction. It reviews the resurgent interest in the themes of attraction and transfer and evaluates new models and typologies that describe those complex processes. It argues that gaps in the current research and new challenges posed by 'globalization' necessitate a new interpretive framework. To that end, a *contextual map of cross-national attraction* is presented and its component parts are described in considerable detail. Examples from the author's previous work on Chinese and American attraction to Japanese education are used to illustrate the uses of this new analytical framework. The article concludes by suggesting the various ways the device may assist in analyzing attraction and transfer and in opening up new areas of research.

Introduction

Research into the perennial theme of 'educational transfer' in comparative and international education faces any number of challenges. For clarity in research, these can perhaps be grouped into three major categories: 'questions of definition (determining the parameters), analysis (identifying the processes) and assessment (judging the outcomes)' (Phillips & Ochs, 2004a, p. 781). This brief article will take up the central question of 'analysis' – how to best identify and understand the complex processes involved in 'educational transfer'. Arguably, it is in this 'analysis' category that the full complexity of the 'transfer' phenomenon continues to attract and challenge scholars in the field. It thus presents itself as a worthy area for continued reflection, commentary, and theorizing.

Yet, no sooner do we set to the task of analyzing transfer processes than we run headlong into the issue of *context*, which has beguiled, stymied, and divided comparative work on transfer since the field's inception. Recall that Michael Sadler did not share the enthusiasm of Jullien de Paris when he eloquently warned against a naive, child-like approach to borrowing that plucked education from its context (Sadler, [1900] 1979). Brian Holmes's 'problem approach' was heavily criticised by Edmund King (1968), in large part for its failure to translate into context-sensitive 'solutions'. Today, the most frequent criticism of organizations like the World Bank, who are actively engaged in transfer, is their continued insensitivity to local context. What is striking about all of this is that despite the paramount importance many in the field place on context in the transfer puzzle, there has been relatively little attempt – notwithstanding a few notable exceptions – to move beyond the commonplace assertion that 'context matters' (Crossley & Watson, 2003, p. 142). In the literature on educational transfer it is not difficult to find these sorts of truisms about context tirelessly repeated and dressed up in all sorts of new and creative ways without any real effort to systematically unpack this essential term or develop conceptual tools to understand contextual influence.

One problem is that most frameworks for analyzing transfer take the 'borrowed' policy as the focal point. This contributes to a myopic view of transfer and conceals the role of context:

If researchers focus on the content of transfer, there is no doubt that they will find a common denominator ... however, if we choose to bring the local context to the fore, direct our attention to agencies of lending and borrowing, and ask why some idea or discourse has been transferred, we gain a completely different understanding of transfer. (Steiner-Khamsi, 2000, p. 158)

If current research on transfer is to move to a deeper level of analysis and understanding, there exists a pressing need to develop analytical and interpretive devices that place less emphasis on the *content* of transfer and focus more attention upon the *context* within which transfer occurs.

To that end, this article describes an attempt at such a framework – a *conceptual map of the context of cross-national attraction* – that facilitates analysis of transfer with particular reference to the underlying issue of context. The conceptual map builds heavily upon existing models and incorporates large amounts of research by other scholars. In this way it is a reorganization or consolidation of much of the recent literature. Yet it also advances several new concepts and develops some crucial themes in the current literature in greater depth. In this way, it is something new.

This new interpretive framework grew out of my own exploration of 'cross-national attraction' – a historical comparison of Chinese and American attraction to Japanese education (Rappleye, 2006). The aim in presenting the framework here is to suggest an additional analytical device to those engaged in researching educational transfer. It is envisaged as both complementing existing models and standing alone as an independent research tool. Given space limitations, this article will describe the framework in relation to the 'cross-national attraction' phase of the policy borrowing cycle (Phillips & Ochs, 2004a). I believe that it is at this stage that it holds the most promise as an analytical device, but because the map focuses heavily on context it may prove to be a useful tool for research into any of the four stages of policy borrowing (Phillips & Ochs, 2004a).

The article will begin by briefly rehearsing the promising work done on 'policy borrowing' in recent years before pointing out the omissions in that literature that this new map attempts to fill. This is followed by a lengthy explanation of the component parts of the new map. A concluding section questions whether the map has wider utility and how it might complement analysis of transfer processes at any stage of the policy borrowing cycle. It is assumed that readers will be familiar with the existing policy borrowing models (Ochs & Phillips, 2002; Phillips & Ochs, 2003), as the discussion that follows is tightly bound to them. It is also worth briefly mentioning the issue of definitions which – as mentioned at the outset – constitutes one of the major challenges of researching educational transfer. It has become almost customary for any work on 'policy borrowing' to begin by pointing out the danger and deceptiveness of the relevant terms. This article – while not unaware or dismissive of the semantic debates and the values underpinning them – is content to use the terms 'policy borrowing', 'educational transfer' and 'cross-national attraction' more or less how they have been used in the mainstream literature thus far. For readers interested in the important nuances and epistemological baggage these terms carry, I refer them to the work of other scholars who have written in depth on the subject (Phillips, 1989, 1992; Ochs & Phillips, 2002; Steiner-Khamsi, 2000, 2004a).

Theorizing Educational Transfer: the story so far

While 'educational transfer' is one of the most enduring motifs in the field of comparative and international education, research into the theme does appear to be undergoing a particular resurgence in recent years. Steiner-Khamsi explains that 'over the last decade, research on educational transfer has experienced a renaissance of a special kind' (2000, p. 157). Invigorated by divisive debates about globalization and an awareness of the arrival of new stakeholders and agents of transfer, the field has responded admirably with a flurry of work dedicated to the transfer theme. Particularly significant among this recent research are attempts to build theory about the transfer process and the development of 'frameworks for analysis' in the form of typologies and models (Ochs & Phillips, 2002; Phillips & Ochs, 2003, 2004a, b; Tanaka, 2003). Those interpretive

frameworks are numerous, their breadth impressive, and their explanatory contribution is indeed an important development in research on the theme of educational transfer.

Most relevant for the purposes of this article are two of those devices – *Four Stages of Policy Borrowing* (Phillips & Ochs, 2003) and *A Structural Typology of 'Cross-National Attraction' in Education* (Ochs & Phillips, 2002) – that attempt to explain and analyze different aspects of the policy borrowing process. The Four Stages of Policy Borrowing are conceived of as shown in Figure 1.

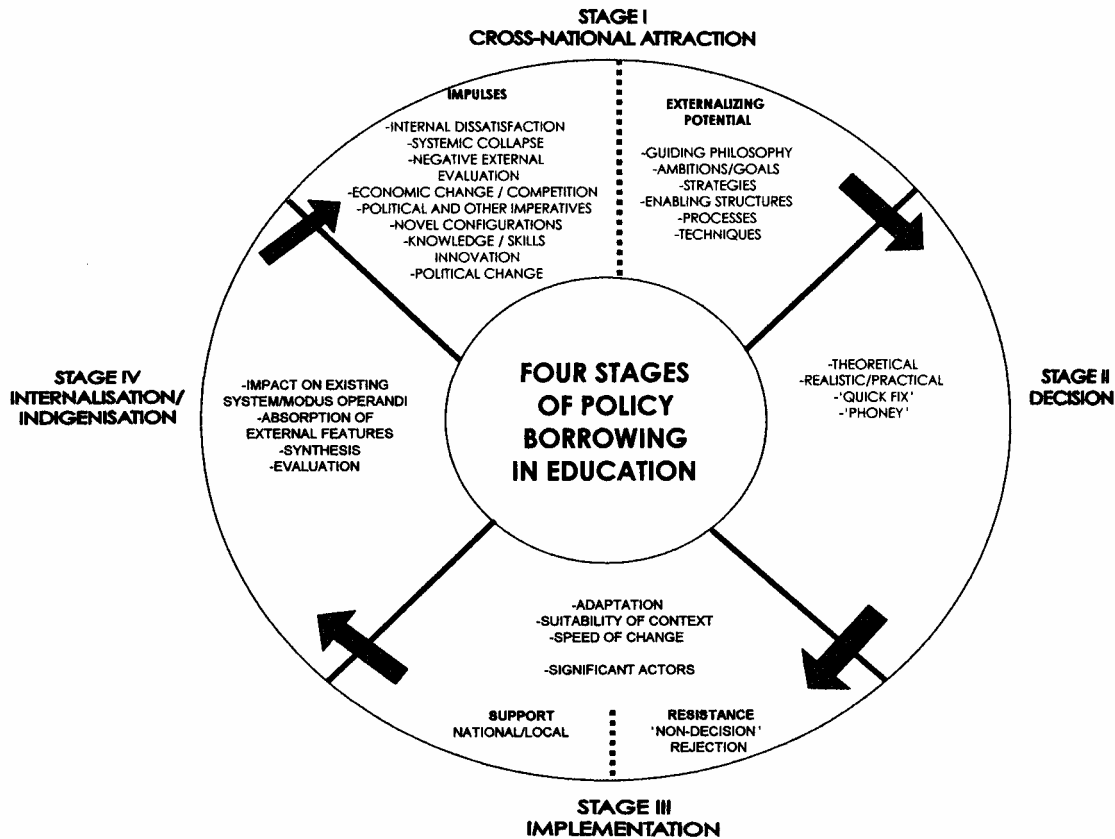


Figure 1. Four stages of educational borrowing (Phillips & Ochs, 2003, 2004a, b).

The figure represents a 'circular model to describe the four stages of policy borrowing in education' (Phillips & Ochs, 2004a, p. 777). Importantly, the authors highlight that the model 'describes an essentially sequential process, with arrows suggesting not causation but temporal linkage' (p. 781). The Four Stages model knits together much of the recent work on transfer and provides a common vocabulary and reference for transfer researchers working on particular 'stages' of the cycle.

The 'cross-national attraction' stage – the focus of the new framework I propose in this article – is of particular importance because it initiates the entire policy-borrowing cycle. As represented in the Four Stages model it is composed of *impulses* ('some kind of stimulus or catalyst that sparks' interest elsewhere [Phillips, 2004, p. 54]) and *externalizing potential* ('elements of the foreign system that are theoretically "borrowable"' (Phillips, 2004, p. 57)). In fact, the externalizing potential side comes from the previous, more elaborate Structural Typology of Cross-National Attraction conceived of as shown in Figure 2.

The Typology is presented as a heuristic device to assist with the 'analysis of *both* the processes *and* the context of "cross-national attraction"' (Ochs & Phillips, 2002, p. 10). In addition to the six foci of educational policy, it presents a backdrop of contextual factors. The authors explain that the aim of the Typology is – among other things – 'to identify important factors in the context of policy transfer ... specifically to examine which contextual factors are important in adopting educational policy' (p. 10). The factors listed – philosophical, historical, cultural, religious, social, 'national character', political, economic, demographic, geographical, linguistic, administrative, technological

– draw the researcher’s attention to different aspects of context, but do not show how to move the analysis further.

Educational Borrowing: Stage One - Cross-national Attraction - (Externalising Potential)

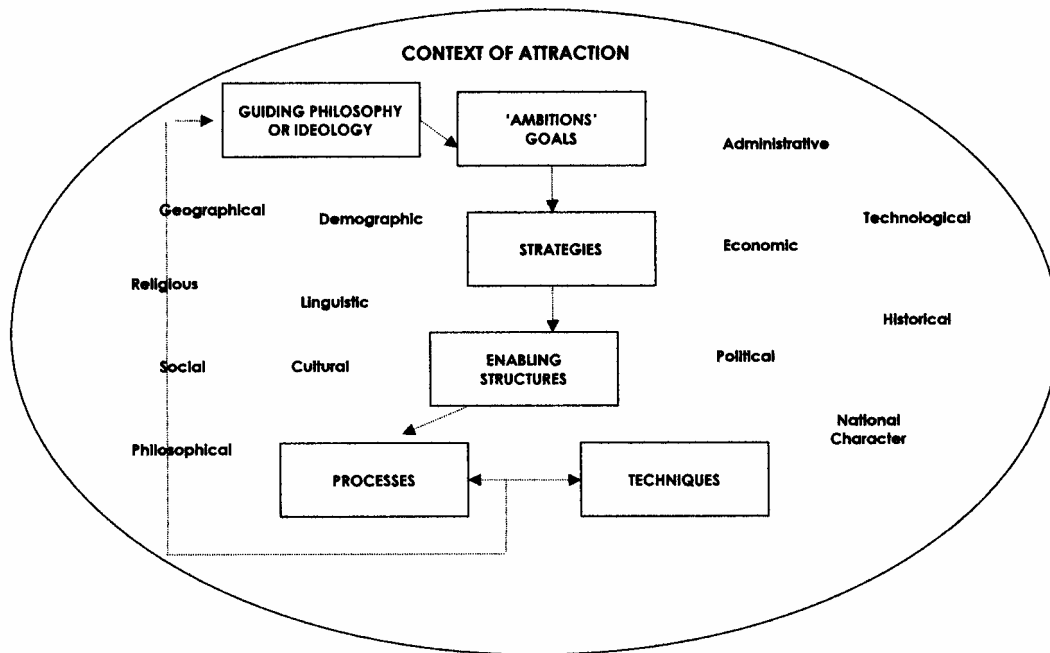


Figure 2. Structural typology of cross-national attraction (Ochs & Phillips, 2002).

The authors devote a whole section of the supporting literature for the Typology to ‘a closer look at context’. They argue that ‘in trying to understand the processes of policy transfer and cross-national attraction, we must also examine the degree to which contextual factors influence the process of attraction’ (p. 33). They attempt to ‘use the model to help identify key influential actors, rather than deterministically quantify the degree of influence’ (p. 35). Yet, the explanation given is brief and in the end the authors concede that ‘the examination of context is extremely complex’ (p. 36). In a subsequent article published two years later, Phillips & Ochs write:

the complex matter of assessing the extent to which a policy observed elsewhere has been deliberately (purposefully) adopted and adapted to fit the home circumstances ... creates for us the task of disentangling the multifarious contextual elements that will impact on the ‘borrowed’ policy. This is the most difficult task which researchers interested in policy borrowing face, and one to which we are currently turning. (2004a, p. 782)

This admission suggests that the authors are still not satisfied with previous work done on context and are still searching for a framework that adequately describes contextual factors.

Thus, despite an upsurge in work on transfer, the contribution of policy-borrowing models, and a Typology of Cross-National Attraction that intends to provide a framework for thinking about context, it appears that building more theory in this area is both a possibility and a necessity.

‘Globalization’ and New Elements of Context

In addition to improving the existing models, there are several new tasks suggested by much of the more recent literature on transfer. Among those demands is a new framework for analysis that (1) pays more attention to agency, (2) accounts for the proliferation of new actors, and (3) reflects the increasing complexity and subtlety of foreign influence. These three points are tightly interwoven and are born out of the changing parameters of education in an era of ‘globalization’. Although ‘globalization’ is deservedly a problematic and contested term in much of the comparative

education literature, the phenomenon does appear to be genuinely changing the nature of transfer and cross-national attraction. Therefore, any new models or theories must account for these shifts. It is worth reviewing each of the new demands in turn.

Steiner-Khamsi – a scholar at the forefront of researching the nexus of ‘globalization’ and transfer – argues that we ‘must direct our attention to agencies resisting, inverting, or indigenizing educational imports’ (2000, p. 158). The Four Stages model holds a place for this type of agency – resistance and indigenization – but only after a policy has been implemented. For clarity, I would like to term this *post-transfer agency*. Yet, Steiner-Khamsi is also explicit that ‘globalization’ necessitates a reformulation of research questions: ‘Why did transfer occur? How was the transfer implemented? *Who were the agents of transfer*’ (2000, p. 164; emphasis added). This is clearly a different type of agency from those forces resisting implementation of a borrowed policy. This is the *pre-transfer agency* of forces introducing foreign influence.

Pre-transfer agency begins the moment the foreign example begins to influence the domestic educational landscape. In other words, pre-transfer agency initiates ‘cross-national attraction’ and asks who is using the foreign example, how they are using it, and for what ends. As educational reforms are always contested, we must assume that there are agents of resistance even at this early stage as well. There is certainly no clear distinction between pre- and post-transfer agency, but that is the crucial point: there are always agencies encouraging and discouraging the foreign example *throughout* the policy-borrowing cycle. This agency – as Steiner-Khamsi points out – needs to be incorporated into the transfer models. Whereas it is in the ‘cross-national attraction’ stage that discourse and policies are transferred, any reformulation of that stage must account for these agencies. As Beech suggests, ‘the question about who are the agents of transfer is fundamental in the redefinition of how we understand foreign influences in education’ (2006, p. 10).

The question of agency implicitly suggests that we must account for multiple actors in transfer processes, a marked break from most previous research and modelling that assumes the state to be the sole actor. Beech argues:

in order to analyze foreign influences in education a wider concept of space is needed. Of course, current theories of foreign influence in education should still consider the state as a fundamental actor. However such theories should also be able to take into account other supra-national actors in the educational field, such as international agencies and regional blocks, and also sub-national actors such as local authorities and institutions. (2006, p. 10)

‘Globalization’ – for reasons that are hotly debated by scholars – has challenged the state’s exclusive role in education. As a result, there has been a proliferation of new actors, stakeholders, and influences on education. Dolowitz & Marsh – political scientists whose work on policy transfer generally can be applied to educational transfer specifically – suggest a list of political actors active in the transfer process, including ‘elected officials, political parties, bureaucrats/civil servants, pressure groups, policy entrepreneurs and experts, transnational corporations, think tanks, supra-national governmental and nongovernmental institutions and consultants’ (2000, p. 10). Ochs (2005) adds to the lists by highlighting networks, league tables, media (communication technology), and sources of funding. Although there are some noteworthy analyses in the literature of how these new actors have introduced foreign ideas (see Steiner-Khamsi’s [2004b] ‘Maris O’Rourke Effect’ and Jansen’s [2004] ‘Importing Outcomes-Based Education in South Africa’ among others), there have been few attempts to move beyond simply identifying these actors. The need is to develop theories about how these new actors interact in ways that spark attraction and transfer.

These new factors naturally create a more complex and subtle environment for cross-national attraction and transfer. Beech argues that ‘under current conditions of so-called “globalization”, foreign influences have become more complex’ (2006, p. 10). Research into transfer must now negotiate agency and a multiplicity of actors. It must also look beyond the familiar nation state unit of analysis and ‘be aware that the transfer of specialized knowledge about education does not only take place from one nation state to another’ (2006, p. 10). Adding to this complexity is the subtlety of the transfer of discourse. ‘Unless we recognize that educational transfer can involve discourses rather than practices, we are unlikely to detect these international movements’, writes Steiner-Khamsi (2000, p. 181), who draws heavily on Jürgen Schriewer’s (1990, 2003) work on discourse formation in comparative education. Recent work extends this idea, highlighting the need to

differentiate between the transfer of 'policy text' and 'policy discourse' (Ochs, 2005) – to be discussed further in the following section.

Recognizing this increasing complexity and ambiguity, Beech calls for 'a new conceptual apparatus' (2006, p. 11) that accounts for the proliferation of actors and the subtle interrelationships among them. It is clear that globalization problematizes theories of educational transfer derived from historical episodes of transfer. There is a need, then, to develop new models to reflect these shifts and respond to these new research demands.

Towards a Conceptual Map of the Context of Cross-National Attraction

Thus far the article has attempted to outline the various factors that necessitate the new Conceptual Map of the Context of Cross-National Attraction described herein. Those were: the need to continue theorizing about processes of transfer, think in greater depth about context, strengthen and develop the existing models, and respond to repeated calls for a framework that reflects the new features of transfer in an era of globalization. With these demands in mind, we can now focus our attention upon the Conceptual Map of the Context of Cross-National Attraction that attempts to address those demands, hereafter referred to simply as the Map.

As a prerequisite to introducing the Map, it is important to first rehearse some of the limitations and dangers inherent in any attempt at mapping or modelling educational concepts. As Phillips & Ochs – two scholars with arguably the most experience in developing models in the field today – explain:

Models seek to provide a concrete representation of processes described in the abstract. They serve as structures to facilitate analysis and discussion and to elucidate temporal and other relationships. They can, however, appear immutable, they can mislead (through the injudicious use of arrows, for example), and they can impede the investigation of complex issues by trapping the analysis within what appears to be a limited framework of possibilities. (2004a, p. 781)

Indeed, this central tension between specificity and utility on the one hand, and generalizability and adaptability on the other, is something that any model or typology must carefully negotiate. The Map does appear to balance this tension well and bring clarity to my own research, but its utility needs to be tested by other researchers. Here again, I might borrow from Phillips & Ochs, who 'regard the model as preliminary, since it will inevitably change as a result of future attempts to apply it to instances of policy borrowing in various contexts' (2004a, p. 781).

The device proposed here also makes every attempt to avoid trapping 'the analysis within what appears to be a limited framework of possibilities' but this is unavoidable to some extent. The Map – as we will shortly see – is predicated on the findings of other researchers who show that the foreign example and cross-national attraction is born of education reform debates (Halpin & Troyna, 1995; Gonon, 1998; Steiner-Khamisi, 2000, 2004a; Ochs, 2005; Sprigade, 2005). It also holds as a basic premise that no single structural change unequivocally necessitates education reform. By this I mean that there is not (and probably can never be) a direct causal link established between changes in the 'wider world' and appropriate response of formal education systems. Education reform is not science, but a highly normative endeavour – perhaps the premier arena for social discourse on values. Thus, education reform – and by extension educational transfer – is based not only upon objective, rational calculation of responses to a changing world, but also on deeply held normative beliefs. This realization underpins the proposed Map, and the full significance of this conviction will be discussed in more detail in what follows.

With the necessary limitations and premises rehearsed, the Map is conceived of as shown in Figure 3. Given its initial visual complexity, it is best to deconstruct the model piece by piece, explaining the component parts individually. Whenever possible the explanation will draw upon the recent literature and include examples to illustrate particular features of the Map. The discussion also connects the new map to the demands of the recent 'transfer' literature rehearsed above. New concepts (such as 'Obstacles') that can further develop our thinking about cross-national attraction and transfer are given particular attention herein.

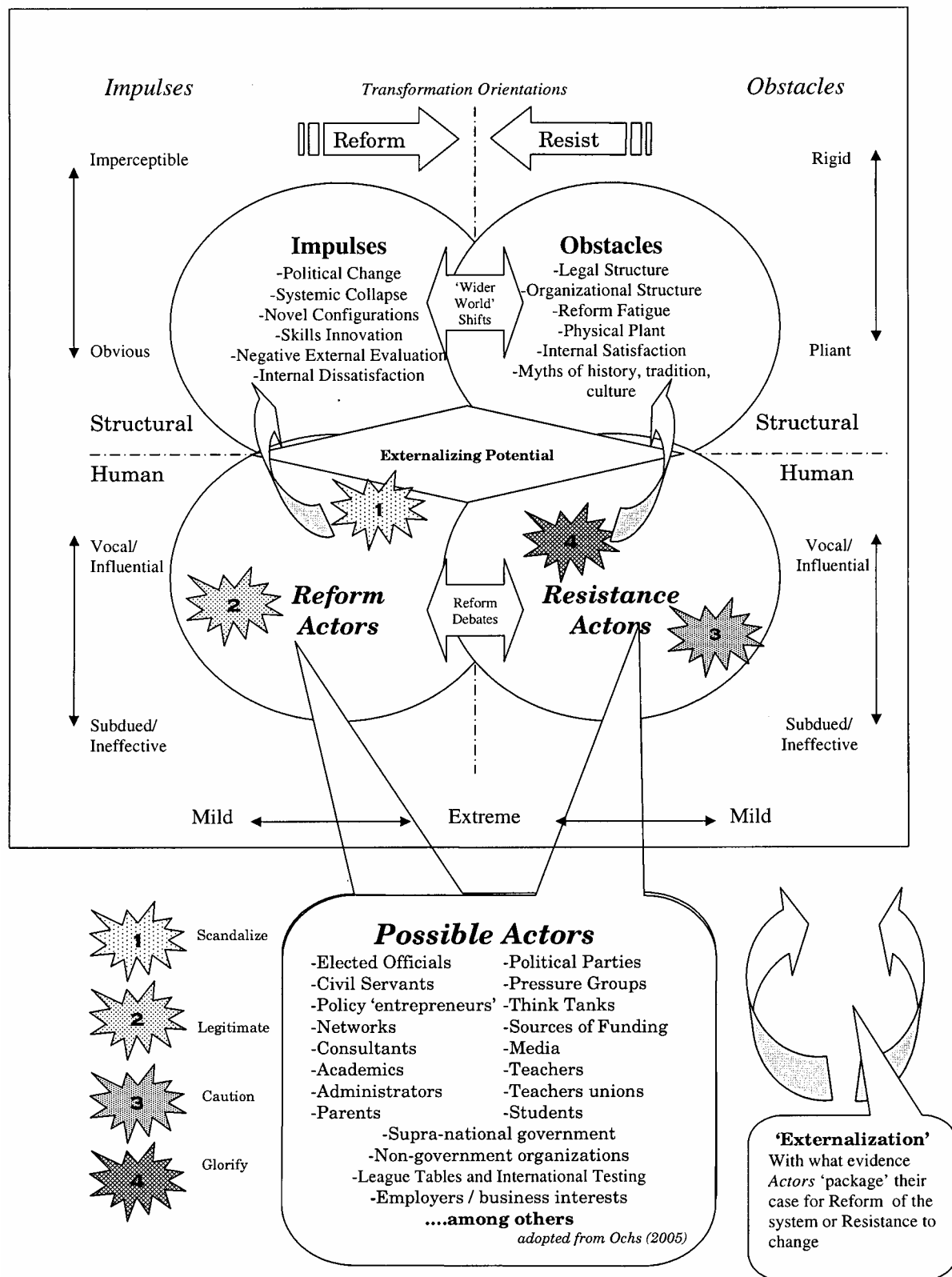


Figure 3. Conceptual map of context of cross-national attraction, and key.

Transformation Orientations: reform

Impulses: structural and human dimensions

Recall that the Four Stages model began with *impulses* that included features such as systemic collapse, internal dissatisfaction, negative external evaluation, economic change/competition, novel configurations, knowledge/skills innovation, and political change among others. The Map retains this important contribution, but suggests that perhaps multiple impulses can influence the system simultaneously and that these might be ranked according to how perceptible those impulses are (the utility of this exercise will be discussed later). In addition, the Map attempts to distinguish these *structural impulses* from another set of *human impulses*. Human impulses are defined as the agencies that are using the foreign example and thereby introducing foreign influence and initiating 'cross-national attraction'. Through this new framework, it is clear that the term 'cross-national attraction' – that inherently takes the monolithic nation state as the agent – is effectively problematized.

This directs our attention to a multiplicity of *actors* who may introduce the foreign example into the discourse of reform and thereby create an *impulse* for change. Who are these actors? The work of Dolowitz & Marsh (2000) and Ochs (2005) described in some detail above provides a starting point. Drawing on that work, the potential list of actors might include: elected officials, political parties, bureaucrats/civil servants, pressure groups, policy entrepreneurs and experts, transnational corporations, think tanks, supra-national governmental, non-governmental institutions, consultants, league tables (or those that produce them), media (communication technology), and sources of funding. It could also conceivably include employers and business interests. Those actors can be plotted according to their influence and rhetoric. Not all actors will be present in every case. Some actors will oppose reform (what I term *resistance actors* and discuss in detail later). Nor will all *reform actors* introduce the foreign example. Yet, to move toward a deeper understanding of the context of 'cross-national attraction' it is worth identifying all the actors and their respective roles in the reform debate.

Reform actors make their case for change by drawing evidence from *structural impulses*. We might imagine that referencing the most perceptible of structural impulses is the easiest and most effective means of garnering support for reforms. The importance of thinking of reform impulses on two levels – structural and human – is that we can begin to deconstruct how reform actors 'package' their case for reform. The work of Jurgen Schriewer employs the term 'externalization' to describe this crucial concept: 'externalizations "filter" the reception and description of an international environment according to the changing problem configurations and reflection situations internal to a given system' (in Schriewer & Martinez, 2004, p. 32). This concept is crucial for getting at a deeper understanding of *attraction*. The Map separates the 'wider world' (structural realm) from the 'reform debates' (human realm) to help the researcher account for 'externalization'.

As argued above, the framework takes education reform as a highly normative endeavour. Perceptions of how education should respond to changes in the world are inextricably bound to values. Obvious *structural impulses* – like Sputnik – do signal a change in the 'wider world', but the conclusion that the Soviets were able to launch a satellite first because their education system was 'better' is an intellectual leap that must be critically deconstructed. The arrow linking the reform actors and structural impulses draws our attention to books like *What Ivan Knows that Johnny Doesn't* (Trace, 1961), which makes a normative case for reform by bringing in the foreign example. Although nothing of substance was 'borrowed' from the Soviet Union, the foreign example was instrumental in pushing education reform. Trace's book appears to be a classic case of 'externalization' to Sputnik that used the foreign example to *scandalize* current practices. This theme will be discussed in greater detail when we turn our attention to the dynamics of cross-national attraction later.

Transformation Orientations: resist

Obstacles: structural and human dimensions

Turning to a discussion of the *obstacles* side of the framework, this Map enters relatively uncharted territory in the literature on cross-national attraction. Few researchers – perhaps unwittingly bound by the term ‘attraction’ – have attempted to theorize about why countries are not attractive. Steiner-Khamsi does ‘argue for a complex study of educational transfer ... that asks who benefits and who loses’ (2000, p. 180), but it appears that the resistance she suggests is conceived of after transfer has occurred. My own research shows that the moment of transfer is not precise and that resistance begins even at the initial stage of ‘cross-national attraction’ (recall the earlier term ‘pre-transfer agency’). These conclusions complement existing research that shows that the foreign example is sometimes used to resist attempts at education reform (to be discussed later). Together these findings suggest the need for a new framework that incorporates a section on *obstacles* – again split into two spheres *structural obstacles* and *resistance actors*. Understanding this side of cross-national influence – why transfer did not take place, why a foreign example was unattractive – is a blind spot in the current transfer research despite the fact that it undoubtedly holds potential as a means of further understanding policy attraction (and may even suggest ways that countries can avoid and/or resist insensitive transfer).

Structural obstacles to reform can include legal and organizational structures, physical plant, reform fatigue, internal satisfaction, and myths of history, tradition, and culture. This list is not exhaustive but a starting point for further reflection and theorizing. These factors mediate and interact with *structural impulses* completely independent of human agency in what might be termed ‘wider world shifts’. The term is necessarily a bit awkward because it intentionally avoids the word context. Context consists of both human and structural elements, but of particular interest here are just the structural elements. This ‘wider world shift’ is an ‘evolutionary process’ that exists completely separate from the ‘semantic construction’ resulting from the interaction of *human and structural* spheres (Schriewer & Martinez, 2004, p. 33). It is worth briefly unpacking each of these types of structural opposition with relevant examples. Given that in the case of Germany there is a clear case of resistance to the near-universal comprehensive school and preference for the tripartite secondary system, it yields several instructive examples:

Legal/organizational structures: the immovability of existing structures and arrangements that mitigates against reform. An example of this is the complexity of decision-making in the German Kultusministerkonferenz (Standing Conference on Education Ministers) and the Verrechtlichung (juridification) through which German ‘advocates of new school models are faced with rigid legal and bureaucratic regulations’ (Ertl & Phillips, 2000, p. 405) that help preserve the status quo. Another example is the tension between federal, state and local prerogatives in systems such as the United States that can magnify the ‘immovability’ of a particular system. One obvious example is that the USA failed to ‘borrow’ anything substantive from Japanese education despite fervent federal government support because it was the purview of state and local authorities to take what they could from the Japanese example.

- *Reform fatigue* – the unresponsiveness of a system in a stage of ‘settling’ after a period of major upheaval or reform. Recall Adenauer’s slogan ‘keine Experimente’ that effectively characterized two decades of non-reform in post-war Germany (Robinsohn & Kuhlmann, in Phillips, 1995, p. 76).
- *Physical plant* – the inability of the existing facilities to accommodate rapid change or conversion. References to this factor are likely to be subtle, which manifests itself in that fact that countries are unlikely to be attracted to other countries that possess a vastly better infrastructure. It would be unlikely that a country which does not yet have computers in classrooms would look to borrow teaching techniques that incorporate multimedia. An illustrative example from the developing world is the current push for Education for All (EFA), requiring 5 million new teachers and 100 million new places (Colclough, 2004). It is nearly impossible for certain countries that lack this basic physical plant/infrastructure to rapidly implement EFA policies no matter how ‘attractive’ those goals appear to particular reform constituencies.
- *Internal satisfaction* – widespread support for the existing educational status quo that resists reform. The prestige of not only the *Gymnasium* but also the *Realschule* in the German tripartite

system was an interesting case in point (see Ertl & Phillips, 2000) until the latest round of PISA (the Programme for International Student Assessment) stripped the system of much of its prestige.

- *Myths of history, tradition, and culture* – the belief in a unique history, tradition, or culture that supports existing structures and *modus operandi*. A good example is German resistance to proposed Allied Occupation reforms that questioned whether America had anything to ‘teach’ Germany about education – given the glory of the German education tradition (Phillips, 1995). A more contemporary example is the intensifying debates in Germany about the *Ganztagsschule* (all day school). Traditionally German students have spent a half-day in school, but this ‘tradition’ is being challenged by ‘wider world shifts’ such as the growing number of women/mothers working full time.

The final point is arguably one of the most provocative features of the new map. The inspiration for its inclusion comes from Holmes (1981), who proposed a typology of educational reform that included ‘forces of reaction’ underpinned by ‘three myths’: society, history and tradition. I have substituted culture for society because the former has become a buzzword in the field in recent years. The term ‘myth’ is designed to be intentionally provocative to induce researchers to think carefully about how these forces and factors play into the reform debates. Of course there exist real ‘wider world’ consequences of history, tradition and culture, but these highly malleable concepts are often fashioned into weapons in the education reform debate. These particular ‘myths’ – history, tradition, culture – are most often employed to resist change. Some have even termed them the ‘rhetoric of stasis’. More work is needed on how much these critical terms reflect actual obstacles to reform and how much they are semantic dykes constructed by various actors to contain and divert reforms. (Letting our minds wander just for a moment, we might also imagine a parallel feature on the *impulse* side that would include myths about the ‘future’ and ‘scientific rationality’ among others. The ‘future’ is as malleable as the past and ‘rationalizing’ an education system is arguably as difficult as creating one to match a particular ‘culture’. Just as the myths of history, tradition, and culture are used to block reform, myths about the ‘future’ or ways to ‘rationalize’ a particular feature of an education system are often used to spur reform [see, for example, Tsuneyoshi (2004) who suggests that a ‘prospective [future] crisis’ is pushing current Japanese education reforms]. Although not included on the original Map this is a promising avenue for future research and theorizing.)

This suggests a parallel dimension of ‘externalization’ on the resistance side:

similarly externalization to ‘tradition’ are not directed at historicizing educational theory traditions or experiences, but rather react to the need to reinterpret and actualize these traditions’ theoretical and/or normative potential in the face of urgent present-day concerns. (Schriewer & Martinez, 2004, p. 32)

As on the *impulse* side, arrows connect the *resistance actors* sphere to the *structural opposition* sphere to call attention to the way that resistance actors ‘package’ their case for maintenance of the status quo. Here again it is crucial for the researcher to attempt to separate real developments from rhetorical framing. It is no easy task, but it is here that we perhaps uncover some of the most important clues about the emergence of ‘cross-national attraction’.

This anticipates the need for a section on *resistance actors*. These are agencies resisting and contesting the reform discourse. These actors could be some of those described as *reform actors* above. Other significant actors not mentioned above might include teacher unions, academics, administrators, teachers, and even parents and students. As with reform actors, these people or groups can be plotted according to their influence and rhetorical style. The list presented here is not exhaustive. Nor is it intended to be different from the list of reform actors. The model conceives of a single pool of all possible actors that the researcher needs to position in the education reform debates as a prerequisite to pinpointing where the foreign example enters the discourse.

Externalizing Potential and Cross-National Attraction

At the center of the Map rests *externalizing potential* and ‘sparks’ of cross-national attraction labeled *legitimate*, *scandalize*, *caution*, and *glorify*. Recall *externalizing potential* was developed as part of the Typology of Cross National Attraction (Ochs & Phillips, 2002) discussed previously. It provides an effective means of classifying the *substance of attraction* – guiding philosophy, ambitions/goals, strategies, enabling structures, process, and techniques. The ‘sparks’ – in contrast – point to the reasons underpinning attraction, the motives for introducing and using the foreign example.

It is worth examining these ‘sparks’ more closely. Ochs (2005) makes a useful distinction between *policy text* and *policy discourse* in educational transfer by building off the work of Stephen Ball (1994). *Policy discourse* is ways of talking about, conceptualizing, and framing education that can be transferred regardless of accompanying policies. Steiner-Khamisi writes that ‘what is being transferred ... is not so much a particular model of education, but the political discourse embedded in a particular education program’ (2000, p. 181). Recalling the Four Stages model, the *cross-national attraction* stage encompasses activities before the decision has been made to actually ‘borrow’ a particular policy, and thus we are primarily concerned here with *policy discourse*.

Ochs provides further direction by classifying the work of other scholars into four *motivations* for using the foreign example:

1. to *caution* against educational reform;
2. to *glorify* current education at home in comparison to other nations (Steiner-Khamisi, 2004)
3. to *legitimate* the adoption of reform of educational policy at home (Gonon, 1998; Novoa & Yariv-Marshall, 2003; Steiner-Khamisi, 2004; Halpin & Troyna, 1995)
4. to *scandalize* policy and practices at home, substantiating and validating the need for reform (Steiner-Khamisi, 2004). (2005, pp. 68-69)

These *motivations* are positioned in the model according to whether they serve the case of reform or resistance, and according to their rhetorical force. To *scandalize* and *legitimate* are ways to spur reform, but *scandalization* perhaps implies a much more aggressive argument. Tentatively, *scandalization* is plotted at the ‘front lines’ of the reform debates near the ‘vocal’ end of the spectrum, although *scandalization* could theoretically be by any reform actor positioned anywhere in the debate. Likewise, *caution* and *glorification* are tools employed to resist change differentiated by the force of rhetoric.

One of the key avenues for further research is to determine whether or not there is some correlation between particular actors, their position in the reform debate, their predilection for introducing the foreign example, and their choice of tactics (i.e. *legitimate*, *scandalize*, *caution*, and *glorify*). Mapping episodes of cross-national attraction will help make patterns more apparent. For example, politicians might be the most vocal and tend to *scandalize* education for political gain (suggested by Halpin & Troyna, 1995). Some academics might use more subdued rhetoric to *legitimate* potential reforms (consider Prais & Wagner, 1986) while others may use the same type of language to *caution* against reform (a good example is Phillips, 1987). Patterns of how, when, and why the foreign example enters the discourse could move research closer to an understanding of the *degree* to which particular contextual factors influence *attraction* and transfer.

One critical question remains: how does *attraction* actually lead to ‘borrowing’? While it is beyond the scope of this article to address this important question, my own research suggests that one way in which *attraction* becomes ‘borrowing’ is when a combination of unlikely allies both use the foreign example to push reform. To take one example from my recent research, over a century ago China ‘borrowed’ its first modern education system from Japan because the Japanese system afforded a compromise between reformers who wanted Western learning and conservatives intent on preserving the Confucian (and thus Imperial) order (Abe, 1987). The reformers pointed out Japan’s successful modernization and military defeat of China to *scandalize* traditional learning that (supposedly) left China weak and defenceless. Conservatives resisted these moves by *glorifying* the Chinese tradition – the Confucian order – which (supposedly) underpinned Japanese military success. At a time when the two sides could not agree on much else, they did agree that Japanese education was a good model for China and ‘borrowed’ on a massive scale (Abe, 1987; Hayhoe, 1992). This type of attraction-cum-borrowing links to work in other disciplines – what anthropologists have termed ‘multivocal symbols’ (Turner, 1974) and what sociologists call

'keywords' (Williams, 1983) – permitting different groups to 'agree while actually holding different understandings and pursuing different agendas' (Goodman, 2003, p. 15). Surely other combinations of factors and actors turn *attraction* into borrowing in different ways. Much more research is needed on how and why this conversion occurs elsewhere.

The Map in Practice: American attraction to Japanese education, 1980s

To ground the abstract description thus far, I will attempt to briefly illustrate how the Map may be used in practice with a familiar example from my own research: American *attraction* to Japanese education in the 1980s. It is an archetypal episode of cross-national attraction in education. While space here does not permit a full analysis, plotting a few of the most prominent aspects of attraction on the Map is instructive.

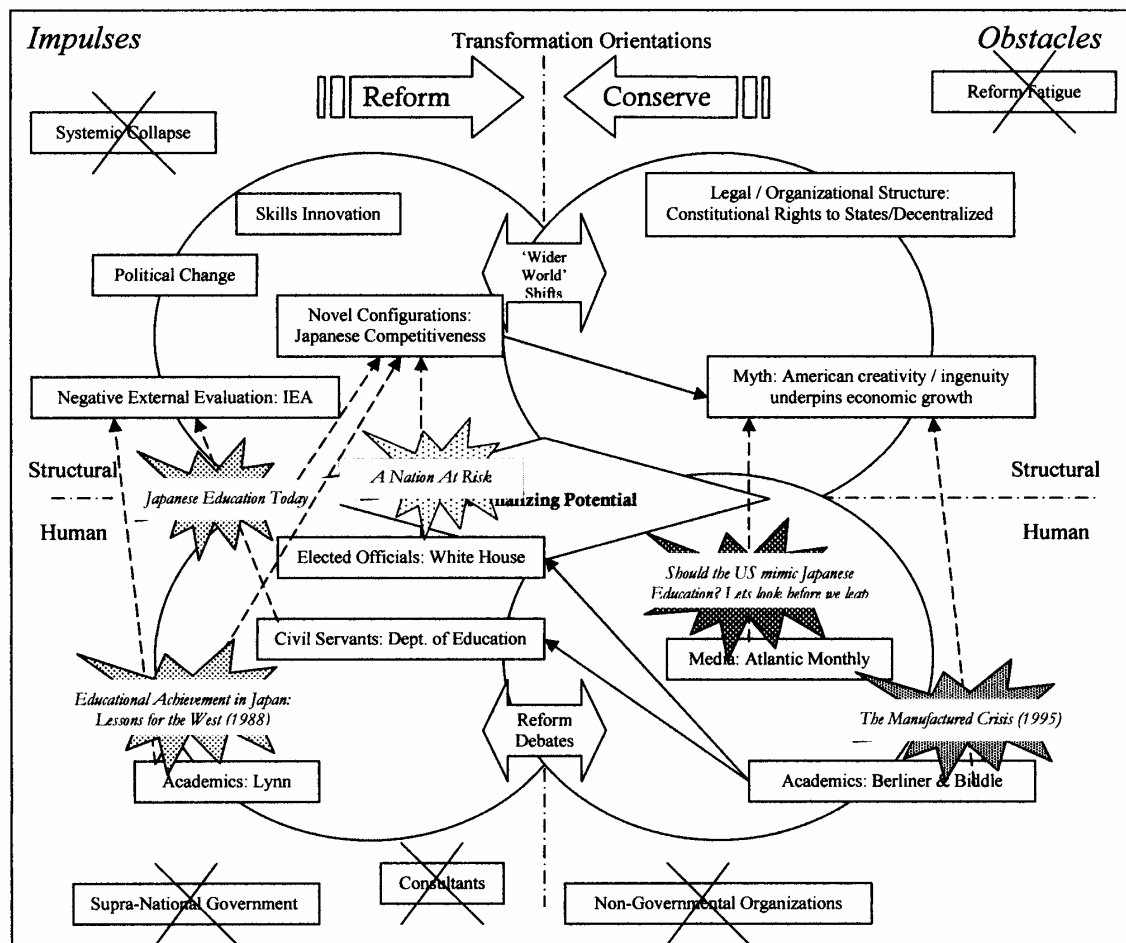


Figure 4. The Map in practice: American attraction to Japanese education.

Again, the initial visual complexity can be rather daunting, reminding the researcher that cross-national attraction is a highly complex phenomenon and rarely reducible to one or two simple correlations. Focusing on *structural impulses*, the Map ranks four significant factors: skills innovation (loss of US industrial jobs, need to 'retool'), political change (1980 election of conservative Ronald Reagan), negative external evaluation (some of the earliest IEA studies released in 1983), and novel configurations (Japan projected to overtake US economy, Japanese business 'beating' THE usa). The *reform actors* that used these structural impulses to 'package' (externalize) their case for reform were – plotted according to their influence and rhetorical style – the elected officials (the Reagan White House through *A Nation at Risk* [National Commission on Excellence in Education, 1983]),

civil servants (US Department of Education through *Japanese Education Today* [OERI Japan Study Team, 1987]), and academics (Lynn, *Educational Achievement in Japan: lessons for the West* [1988]). In fact, this is only a few of the myriad reform actors that played a part in American attraction to Japan. My own research highlights the role of think tanks (the conservative Heritage Foundation's lecture series about US education in 1991) and sources of funding ('to counteract the escalating chorus of economically focused "Japan-bashing" various US and Japanese groups began to allocate new funds to finance study trips ... it is because of the availability of funds that interest in Japanese education has risen in the United States' [Cummings, 1989, p. 294]) as well. This portion of the Map could be developed in much more detail, but these examples suffice to show how the Map is used in practice.

In a similar fashion, the features of *resistance* – both *structural obstacles* and *resistance actors* – can be inventoried. Arrows connecting *reform actors* to *resistance actors* (i.e. Berliner & Biddle to White House) show an explicit confrontation in the reform debates. Arrows connecting *structural impulses* and *structural obstacles* show shifts in the 'wider world' (Japanese competitiveness displaces 'myths' of American ingenuity). Factors are crossed off if the research reveals that they are indeed insignificant, as I have done with systemic collapse, supra-national organizations, consultants, and non-governmental organizations. Conceived of in this way, the list of potential *actors*, *impulses*, and *obstacles* presents a checklist of sorts that drives and structures research.

Plotting all of this onto a single Map yields a robust panorama of the context of American attraction. It reveals a marked imbalance in the number of references to Japan by those favoring reform vis-à-vis resisting reform. It highlights that highly influential actors were employing extreme rhetoric to push their case for reform. *Resistance actors* had little on which to base their case for 'caution' against the Japanese example, while *reform actors* could 'package' their case with any number of *impulses*. In fact, many of the resistance actors appear to be simply reacting to the fervour caused by the reform actors. These conclusions have implications for a deeper understanding of attraction. The Map provides a concrete way of sorting and tracking the complexity.

One final note needs to be addressed: externalizing potential. Given that the Map already appears quite complex, the illustration above did not attempt to represent *externalizing potential* therein. Yet, it is clear that in each case of 'externalization' described above the *externalizing potential* typology proposed by Ochs & Phillips (2002) can be employed to sort the foci of that attraction. Another way to conceptualize this might be as shown in Figure 5.

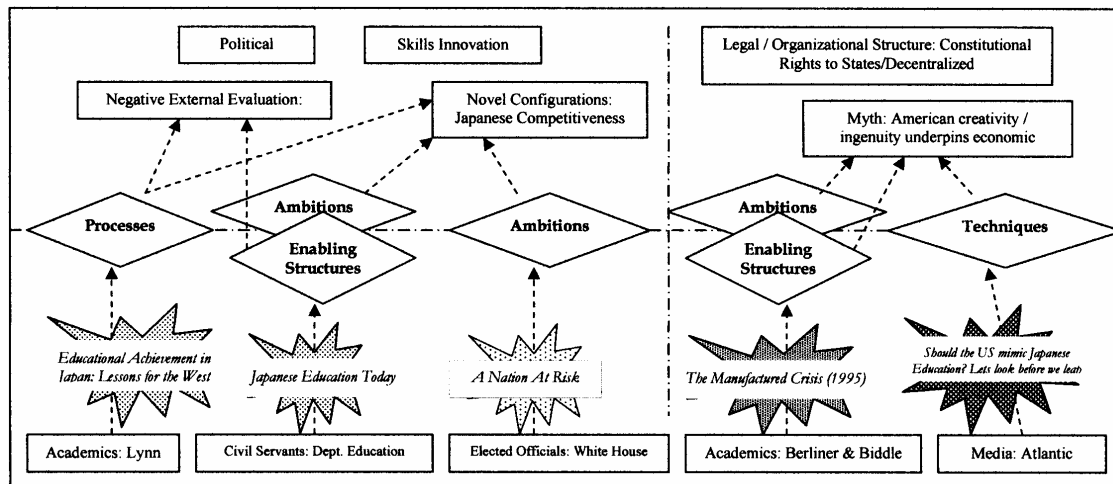


Figure 5. The Map in practice: nature of American attraction to Japanese education.

Research into cross-national attraction would do well to use the *externalizing potential* classifications to understand *what* is attractive and the Map to understand *why* attraction occurs. Undoubtedly these aspects are inextricably bound, but more research is needed to understand the interplay

among these two aspects of attraction and uncover clusters and patterns of coincidence that can drive a deeper understanding of attraction.

Other Potential Uses of the Map and Avenues for Further Research

Although this article has described the map in relation to the 'cross-national attraction' stage, it may complement analysis of other stages of the transfer cycle as well. If the contextual map was plotted and re-plotted at each of the four stages it would reveal how context had shifted during the policy-borrowing cycle (see Figure 6).

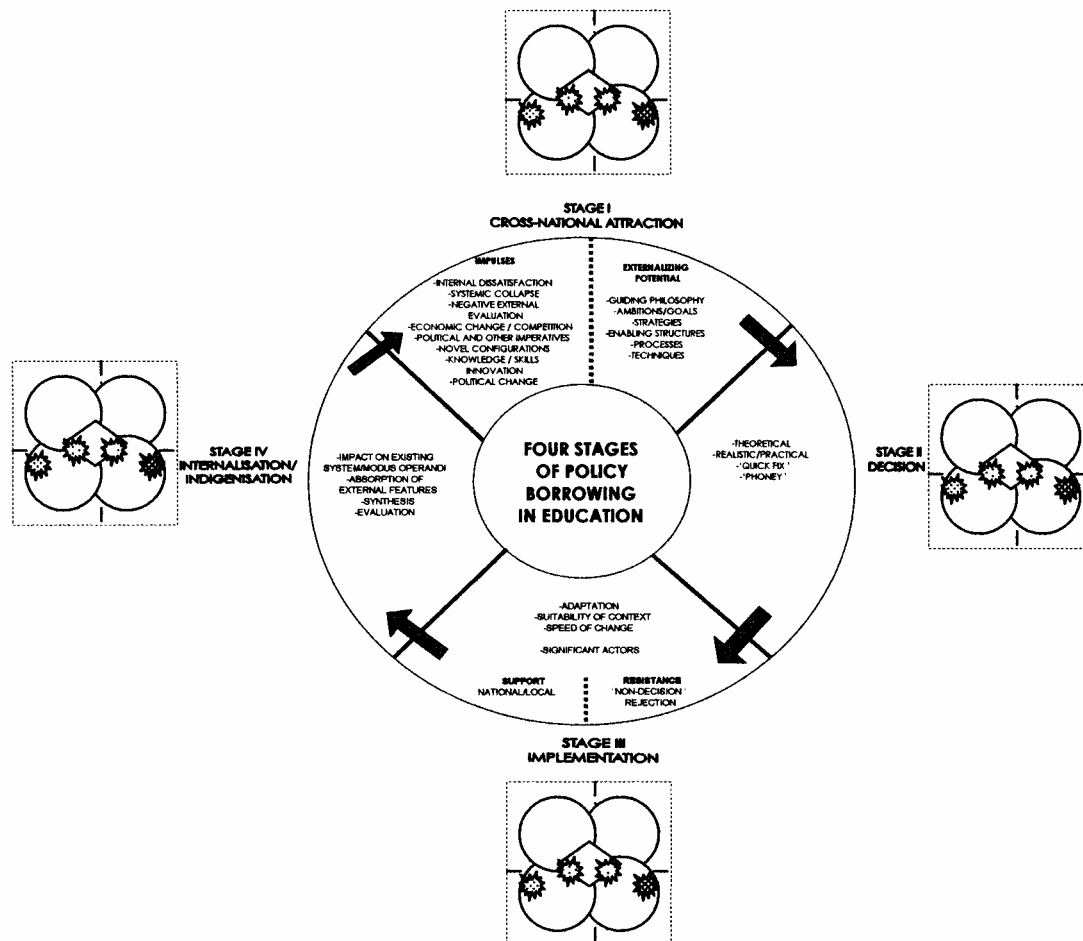


Figure 6. Conceptualizing shifts in context through the transfer cycle.

These 'snapshots' would reveal the shifting nature of context. Akin to time-lapse photography, it might reveal more clearly the evolution of context over the life of a borrowed policy. This technique would make it apparent which actors become significant at particular times, how their 'packaging' of the foreign example changes, and identify which tactics become significant at particular stages of the borrowing cycle. Spreen argues that 'borrowing strategies change over time along with changes in the policymakers' status, legitimacy, and position' (2004, p. 233). Her work on the 'vanishing origins' of borrowed policies is precisely the type of conclusions that one would expect to become apparent by mapping context throughout the policy-borrowing cycle.

In a similar way, the map might be used to chart how attraction and transfer in a particular national context have changed through history. It is widely held that Japanese education has been significantly influenced by the foreign example at each of its 'three great education reforms' but my research suggests that the dynamics of that attraction and transfer has changed significantly over

time. The research employs the map to conceptualize historical shifts in context as shown in Figure 7.

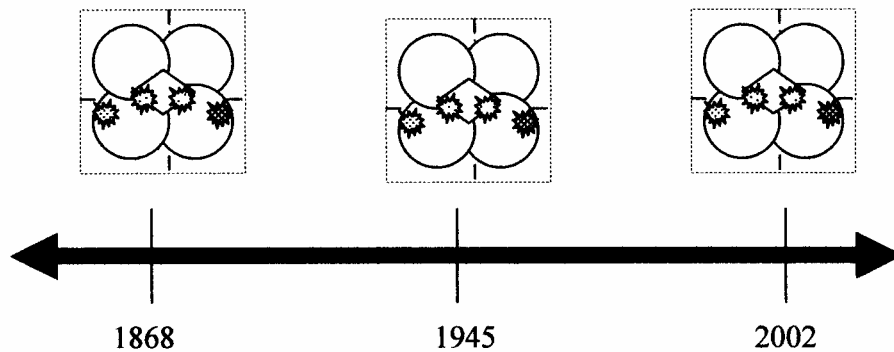


Figure 7. Conceptualizing historical shifts in context (with reference to Japanese education).

More specifically, recall the previous discussion of how globalization has introduced a multitude of new actors. In an earlier era of transfer, consultants, supra-national organizations, and international assessment tests – for example – were non-existent. Now these *actors* and *impulses* abound and interact in increasingly complex ways. In some respects, this represents a new era for policy-borrowing research. We must draw from the past literature on transfer, but we must also account for shifts wrought by globalization by reorganizing and improving upon frameworks developed on episodes of transfer in a previous era. The map could provide some direction for much-needed research into how the nature of transfer has changed through history.

An additional bonus to the map being conceived in this way is that it gives comparativists a bit of inspiration and a road map. It inspires because it shows that we as comparativists can play an important role in the *transfer* process because it has a human element. The new model is a road map because it shows comparativists how to reach a more effective position in influencing debate on the foreign example. One scholar remarked that:

Generally speaking, comparative educators have lacked the stature to move to the center of the national debate ... one reason for the inability of comparative educators to exert direct influence on the national debate may derive from their methodological stance: comparative educators tend to look abroad rather than to home, and thus are clumsy in communicating the significance of foreign practices to domestic audiences. And as long as comparative educators focus primarily on foreign practice, they are unlikely to achieve stature in their own systems. This suggests the need for more comparative educators to ... devote equal attention to the characteristics of exogenous and indigenous educational systems. (Cummings, 1989, p. 302)

As recommended, the map encourages us to make the connection between our work and the 'home' context explicit. By connecting our research on foreign systems to either *impulses* or *obstacles* in the 'home' country we can play a part in moulding *context*. This can be for or against attraction. If, for example, comparativists were *against* borrowing the foreign example, they would use the foreign example to *caution* or *glorify*. They would downplay the effect of *impulses* and highlight the importance of certain aspects of *structural obstacles*. They might also point out how politicians or other scholars were themselves moulding *context* by *scandalizing* or *legitimizing*, as Berliner & Biddle did in the *Manufactured Crisis* (1995).

The point is that by being more aware of the interplay between *impulses*, *obstacles*, and *actors*, comparativists can situate themselves and their work accordingly. This returns to Cummings's point: if we simply produce descriptive case studies and leave others to apply the lessons in the 'home context' we will continually be disappointed in how our research is used. The argument that academics should produce neutral findings and not engage in politics is curious. Policy borrowing is by definition a highly *political* process.

Yet, neither should this be understood as simply 'playing politics'. It is part and parcel to the exercise of comparative education. Recall Noah's chronology in his classic 'Use and Abuse of Comparative Education':

The authentic use of comparative study resides not in wholesale appropriation and propagation of foreign practices but in careful analysis of the conditions under which certain foreign practices deliver desirable results, *followed by consideration of ways to adapt those practices to conditions found at home.* (1984, p. 562; emphasis added)

If we as comparativists do not make the connection between our research, transfer processes, and the home context explicit someone less knowledgeable will. Using this framework to position our own research might help improve the important skill of 'communicating the significance of foreign practices to domestic audiences'.

While this may appear a bit ambitious, the potential uses of the map presented herein are intended to highlight the need for more work in these critical areas. Understanding how context shifts during the life of a borrowed policy, how attraction and transfer has changed through history, and how to make comparative research more influential in transfer processes are among the most promising avenues of further research in the field.

Conclusions

This article has attempted to outline some of the current methodological debates about educational transfer and cross-national attraction. It discussed how the field has responded to resurgent interest in the theme of transfer with new models and typologies that describe these complex processes. It then called attention to the blind spots in the current research and presented a Contextual Map of Cross-National Attraction that attempts to fill those voids, describing its component parts in considerable detail. Finally, it suggested new ways that the map might be used in some promising avenues of further research.

The Conceptual Map of the Context of Cross-National Attraction is provisional and will naturally evolve and improve the more it is used to analyse attraction and transfer in various settings. Phillips could well have described this framework when he wrote of his own models:

The devices described above are intended to promote processes of analysis, explanation, and understanding. Like all such devices they are open to criticism and amendment and the principal purpose of describing them here ... is to encourage reaction that will result in their further development. (2004, p. 65)

I anticipate that some readers will object to the notion of attraction as simply tactical manoeuvres in a big 'edu-political' chess match. In fact, it is doubtful that most actors – except perhaps elected politicians – think in such terms. Still, conceptualizing attraction in this way appears to be helpful regardless of whether actors are *consciously* positioning themselves in the wider reform debate. Then again, it is not difficult to image that this 'intentionality' may have repercussions for what is actually borrowed.

These concerns remind us just how much of a Gordian knot educational transfer really is. Yet, it is precisely this complexity that challenges the comparative mind and has made transfer one of the most enduring themes of the field. 'Globalization' has only added to the theme's importance and complexity. Transfer is indeed 'an issue that is becoming increasingly important and problematic with the intensification of the pace and scope of globalization ... albeit in more diverse and often subtle ways' (Crossley & Watson, 2003, p. 60). More theorizing about the nature of cross-national attraction and transfer is the key to keeping pace with those changes. We must match this diversity and subtlety with increasingly sophisticated theories and models of educational transfer. It is one of the foremost challenges facing research in comparative and international education today.

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